

Corticosteroids (Steroids)

What are they?

There are two main types of steroids. **Anabolic** steroids build muscle. **Corticosteroids** — the type we prescribe — reduce **swelling, pain and inflammation** and **calm the immune system**, but can cause muscle loss.

Prednisone/prednisolone is the most commonly used. We often prescribe it to reduce swelling in or around the brain and spinal cord, and to treat immune-mediated diseases and some cancers.

Common short-term side effects

- Increased hunger and weight gain
- **Increased thirst and urination** (more accidents are possible)
- Panting
- Pot-bellied appearance
- Muscle loss

Possible long-term or high-dose side effects

- **Stomach or intestinal ulcers and bleeding**
- Higher risk of **infections** (including urinary infections)
- Pancreatitis
- High blood pressure; blood clots/strokes
- Muscle, tendon and ligament weakness
- Thin skin and hair coat changes; diabetes

Because of these risks, we try to make the right diagnosis before starting steroids, use the **lowest effective dose**, and use other medications when possible.

Important safety rules

1. **Never give steroids together with an NSAID** (see the list below, or human drugs like ibuprofen or aspirin) — this can cause dangerous internal bleeding.
2. **Never stop steroids suddenly** without talking to your veterinarian — the body needs time to adjust.
3. Give with food.

Call your veterinarian urgently for

- Decreased appetite or vomiting
- **Dark, black or bloody stool**
- Difficulty breathing
- Extreme lethargy or weakness

Common steroids

Prednisone · Prednisolone · Dexamethasone · Methylprednisolone (Medrol) · Triamcinolone · Cortisone · Budesonide

Common NSAIDs — do not combine with steroids

Aspirin · Carprofen (Rimadyl) · Etodolac (EtoGesic) · Deracoxib (Deramaxx) · Meloxicam (Metacam) · Firocoxib (Previcox) · Grapiprant (Galliprant) · Robenacoxib (Onsior) · Ibuprofen/naproxen (human — **never** give to pets)